Predatory Invitations as Extended Phenotype: A Parasitic Spontaneous Order Analysis Across Academic and Literary Publishing

Ignacio Adrián Lerer · Independent Researcher · Buenos Aires, Argentina

ORCID: 0009-0007-6378-9749 · Zenodo community: law-as-extended-phenotype

Working paper — March 30, 2026. A prior version of this analysis was submitted as manuscript #9516 to the Journal of Comparative Law and Legal Theory (JCLLT); this paper extends that work to the literary publishing domain and incorporates empirical material from 2025–2026.

Abstract

This paper develops a unified theoretical account of predatory publishing as a case of Parasitic Spontaneous Order (PSO) — a self-organizing system of extraction that arises without central coordination and stabilizes through evolutionary dynamics. Drawing on the Extended Phenotype Theory of Law (EPT), the Heteronomous Bayesian Updating (HBU) framework, the Generalized Intentionality Mismatch Theorem (GIMT), and the Dennett-Nash Gap formalism developed in the Lerer Research Program, the paper analyzes predatory publishing practices across two primary domains: academic journals and creative/literary publishing. A live empirical specimen — an unsolicited invitation received on March 30, 2026, purportedly from Studies in Science of Science (ISSN 1003-2053) — is analyzed as a primary case. The paper identifies six structurally isomorphic predatory modalities, establishes six structural invariants common to all, formalizes the fitness function of the Predatory Invitation Phenotype (PIP), models the evolutionary arms race between predatory operators and detection mechanisms, and applies the PSO equilibrium analysis to explain why the system is evolutionarily stable under current institutional conditions. The theoretical contribution rests on arguing that these phenomena are not isolated frauds but instances of a repeatable, structured system that exploits symbolic recognition as its primary currency — with financial extraction as a downstream consequence, not the fundamental driving mechanism.

Keywords: predatory publishing; extended phenotype theory; parasitic spontaneous order; symbolic recognition; hijacked journals; vanity publishing; evolutionary stable strategy; HBU; Dennett-Nash Gap; predatory invitations.

1. Introduction

Among the most consequential structural vulnerabilities of contemporary knowledge production is what this paper terms the symbolic recognition gap: the distance between the universally distributed human desire to be recognized as a producer of knowledge or art, and the scarcity of access to the institutional mechanisms — peer-reviewed journals, reputable presses, prize committees, editorial boards — through which that recognition is legitimately conferred. Into this gap, a class of operators has evolved that offers what appears to be recognition through the legitimate symbolic infrastructure of publishing, but delivers no actual epistemic or cultural function. The unsolicited invitation — arriving in a researcher's inbox or a poet's mailbox with the apparatus of selection, certification, and institutional prestige — is the primary transmission vector of this system.

The existing literature on predatory publishing is substantial but theoretically thin. Empirical studies have catalogued the growth of predatory journals, characterized their markers, traced their geographic distribution, and analyzed the motivations of authors who publish in them. Beall's List and its successors have provided operational taxonomies. The Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker now tracks over 400 such operations. What has been largely absent from this literature is a formal theoretical account — one capable of explaining not just what predatory publishing does, but why it is structurally stable, why it recurs across radically different domains (academic science and amateur poetry), why it evolves predictably in response to detection pressure, and why the financial transaction is structurally downstream of a prior symbolic transaction.[1][2][3][4][5][6][7][8][9][10]

This paper provides that account. It does so by applying the Extended Phenotype Theory of Law (EPT), which treats cultural replicators — norms, institutional forms, communicative templates — as subject to the same evolutionary pressures as biological replicators, and specifically by deploying the Parasitic Spontaneous Order (PSO) construct, which describes systems where order and stability emerge without central design from the distributed fitness-maximizing behavior of agents exploiting shared infrastructural resources. The paper further integrates Bourdieu's analysis of symbolic capital and field theory, the evolutionary game theory of Maynard Smith and Price, and empirical documentation from investigative journalism, writer advocacy organizations, and the academic literature on predatory publishing.[11][12][13][14][15]

This paper operates within the Extended Phenotype Theory of Law (EPT) research program, understood in the Lakatosian sense (Lakatos, 1978): a progressive research program with a non-negotiable hard core (cultural replicators subject to Darwinian selection), an adjustable protective belt (specific parameters of the PSO and PIP fitness functions), and a positive heuristic directing expansion toward new empirical domains. The present analysis constitutes an application of that heuristic to predatory publishing — a domain where the program's core mechanisms (replicator dynamics, extended phenotype construction, Parasitic Spontaneous Order) generate falsifiable predictions that can be evaluated against the substantial empirical literature reviewed below.

The contribution is structured as follows. Section 2 presents and analyzes the primary empirical specimen — the live invitation received on March 30, 2026. Section 3 develops the theoretical framework. Section 4 presents the cross-domain structural analysis across six predatory modalities. Section 5 formalizes the Predatory Invitation Phenotype fitness function and its evolutionary dynamics. Section 6 applies the PSO equilibrium analysis. Section 7 traces the arms race with detection mechanisms, including the AI-assisted personalization wave of 2024–2026. Section 8 develops the Bourdieu-EPT synthesis on symbolic capital exploitation. Section 9 discusses implications for the Lerer Research Program and future directions. Section 10 concludes.

2. The Primary Empirical Specimen

At 1:34 AM on March 30, 2026, an unsolicited email was received addressed to Adrián Lerer. The sender address was `deepakgupta346q@gmail.com`. The subject line read: Invitation to Submit Your Rese... The full body text reads:

> "Dear Researchers, We are pleased to invite you to submit your scholarly work to Studies in Science of Science (ISSN: 1003-2053), a multidisciplinary, peer-reviewed journal indexed in Scopus and listed by UGC and DGRSDT. Journal Features: Global Visibility: Your published work will reach an international academic community. Quality Peer Review: All submissions undergo a rigorous evaluation process. Open Access: Articles are freely available online to support wide dissemination of knowledge. For submission details and additional information, please visit: sciencejournal.eu/index.php/studies-in-science-of-science/about/submissions — Best regards"

2.1 Specimen Classification

This specimen belongs to the hijacked/cloned journal category — a subtype of predatory publishing operation that is analytically distinct from ordinary predatory journals. A hijacked journal does not construct a fake institutional identity from scratch but appropriates the identity of a legitimate, indexed journal. The genuine Studies in Science of Science is an established Chinese publication — ISSN 1003-2053, Scopus-indexed, with a traceable academic history. The fraudulent operation at `sciencejournal.eu` co-opts the journal's title, ISSN, and indexing credentials while operating through an entirely different institutional infrastructure. The domain `sciencejournal.eu` bears no relationship to the Chinese publisher of record.[16][3][17]

This is a well-documented pattern. Abalkina's 2024 study in the Journal of the American Society for Information Science and Technology identified at least 67 hijacked journals that had penetrated Scopus since 2013, of which 33 had indexed unauthorized content directly and 23 had compromised the homepage link in Scopus's journal profile. The Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker, maintained by Abalkina, reached 400 entries in December 2025. A 2025 report documented the November 2024 "Springer Global Publication" wave, in which clones of Elsevier, Springer Nature, and AMA journals were created using domains such as `sciencedirects.com` and `springer.uk.com`, with counterfeit DOIs assigned to submitted articles.[3][18][19][20]

2.2 Diagnostic Analysis of the Specimen

Ten EPT/PSO diagnostic markers are simultaneously present in the specimen.

First: the email co-opts the name of a legitimate Scopus-indexed journal. The ISSN 1003-2053 belongs to the authentic journal; the email parasitizes its indexing status without any institutional connection to it. This is the defining maneuver of the hijacked journal: it converts the legitimate journal's accumulated credibility into a direct subsidy for the fraudulent operation.[17]

Second: the sender address is `deepakgupta346q@gmail.com`. Multiple independent expert sources identify personal Gmail addresses as a primary operational signature of fake and cloned journal solicitations, since legitimate journals operate exclusively through institutional domains. The Grudniewicz et al. consensus definition of predatory journals explicitly identifies non-verifiable contact details as among the most important markers.[4][21][22][23]

Third: the email's claims are uniformly vague and unfalsifiable. "Rigorous evaluation process," "global visibility," "wide dissemination of knowledge" — these phrases perform a legitimacy signal without containing any verifiable content. Grudniewicz et al.'s Delphi consensus identified this pattern: journals with an "unprofessional look and feel" combined with unverifiable claims about peer review are among the most reliably identified predatory operators.[5][4]

Fourth: no editorial specificity is present. There is no editor's name, no submission scope, no stated turnaround time, no mention of article processing charges. The absence of such specificity is itself diagnostic: legitimate journals communicate their editorial character; fraudulent operators defer all disclosure to a URL that typically reveals fees only after the author has invested time in the submission process.

Fifth: the solicitation is generic. "Dear Researchers" is a mass-addressed form letter. Studies of predatory journal invitations have established that this mode of solicitation — distinguished from genuine editorial invitations by its universal rather than field-specific targeting — is a key operational marker. A 2025 PubMed editorial found that only 7.35% of solicitation emails from predatory journals were relevant to the recipients' stated research area.[21][24]

Sixth: the email arrived at 1:34 AM — a time window consistent with automated batch-sending from a different time zone, a further operational signature of large-scale fraudulent operations rather than genuine editorial outreach.[25]

Seventh: the Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker and Beall's List provide the infrastructure necessary to verify this specimen as fraudulent, but the verification requires active effort by the recipient. The fraudulent invitation is designed to extract submission behavior before that verification occurs.

Eighth: the AI-generated spam literature documents that as of April 2025, 51% of all spam was AI-generated, with academic publishing solicitations representing one of the most rapidly growing categories. The 2025 Thesify guide notes that generative AI now enables predatory operators to craft invitations that reference specific prior publications, conference presentations, and online profiles — achieving a 54% click-through rate compared to 12% for traditional phishing.[26][27][21]

Ninth: the Google Scholar profile scraping that identifies Adrián Lerer's research on extended phenotype theory and law is reflected in the journal title chosen — Studies in Science of Science is a multidisciplinary title with apparent relevance to a researcher working on science studies and evolutionary theory.

Tenth: no article processing charge is mentioned in the body. This deferred disclosure of fees is itself a documented predatory tactic — the reader has already opened, read, and begun considering the invitation before encountering the financial extraction request.[28][29]

3. Theoretical Framework

3.1 The Extended Phenotype and Cultural Replication

Richard Dawkins introduced the concept of the extended phenotype in 1982 to capture a fundamental insight about the unit of natural selection: that genes are properly understood not as programming organisms but as maximizing their own replication through whatever structures they can build in the external world. The beaver dam, the caddisfly case, the spider web — these are as much the expression of the beaver's, caddisfly's, and spider's genes as their anatomical structures. The extended phenotype is gene action that extends beyond the organism's body into the environment, including the bodies of other organisms.[12]

Dawkins articulated the central theorem of the extended phenotype as follows: "An animal's behaviour tends to maximize the survival of the genes for that behaviour, whether or not those genes happen to be in the body of the particular animal performing it". The parasitic case is the most theoretically extreme: the flatworm Leucochloridium paradoxum manipulates the behavior of its snail host to make the snail expose itself to predation by birds — the worm's next host — a behavior that is profoundly maladaptive for the snail but serves the worm's genes.[30][31]

The EPT framework applies this logic to cultural replicators — memes in Dawkins's original formulation — and in particular to the norms, institutions, and communicative templates that constitute the infrastructure of social recognition. A predatory publishing operation builds extended phenotypic structures — journals, editorial boards, certificate-issuing societies, anthology series — not to perform the functions those structures serve in the legitimate publishing ecosystem, but to maximize the replication rate of the extraction mechanism. The invitation is the spore of this extended phenotype.

3.2 Parasitic Spontaneous Order

Hayek's analysis of spontaneous order identifies a class of social phenomena in which order — stable, patterned, coordinated behavior — emerges without central design as the unintended consequence of distributed individual actions, each agent pursuing its own interests without explicit coordination. The price system is Hayek's paradigm case: no central authority coordinates the information embedded in prices, yet that information is transmitted effectively through decentralized interaction.[13][32]

The PSO construct synthesizes Dawkins's extended phenotype logic with Hayek's spontaneous order analysis to describe a subclass of systems where distributed order emerges not from mutually beneficial coordination but from the distributed exploitation of shared resources. In PSO, each operator's fitness is maximized by extracting value from an infrastructure — the symbolic capital of legitimate publishing — that it did not create and cannot maintain. The system as a whole is wasteful and destructive, but it is stable because the logic of each individual operator's behavior generates evolutionary pressure on all other operators to adopt the same strategy. Defection from the predatory strategy (becoming a legitimate publisher) would reduce fitness relative to competitors. The PSO is an evolutionary trap.

The predatory publishing ecosystem satisfies the three conditions for PSO activation. There is visible inequality in access to legitimate publishing recognition — the gap that motivates submission to any outlet offering what appears to be publication. There are organized intermediaries — operations with scraped email lists, web infrastructure, fake editorial boards, domain registrations, and, as of 2024–2026, AI-assisted personalization capabilities. And there is a structurally weakened enforcement environment — Scopus cannot prevent hijacking at scale, the SFWA and Authors Guild issue warnings but have no binding authority over predatory publishers, and no regulatory body has jurisdiction over cross-jurisdictional predatory operations.[3][28][33][19][26][21][27][34]

3.3 The Dennett-Nash Gap Applied to Predatory Publishing

The Dennett-Nash Gap formalizes a class of strategic interactions in which an actor operating at a lower level of intentionality (Dennett's L1 — optimizing without genuine intentional states) exploits targets operating at a higher level (L3 — attributing genuine intentions, beliefs, and values to counterparties). Predatory publishing operators are functionally L1 agents: they optimize for fee extraction through template-driven mass solicitation, without genuine editorial intention or reputational stake in the academic community. Their targets are L3 agents: researchers and writers who interpret incoming communications as originating from entities with genuine intentions, editorial standards, and professional commitments.

The gap between these levels generates a systematic exploitation surplus. The fraudulent operator appropriates the symbolic vocabulary of legitimate publishing — peer review, ISSN, Scopus indexing, editorial rigor — without bearing the costs that legitimate publishers incur to earn the right to use that vocabulary. The target cannot easily distinguish L1 mimicry from L3 authenticity because the mimicry has been specifically engineered to pass cognitive filters calibrated for L3 actors.

The Dennett-Nash Gap for the predatory invitation can be expressed as:

$$\Delta_{pred} = SA_{mimicry} + ICS_{noreview} - MP_{detection} + SIP_{noreputationstake}$$

where $SA_{mimicry}$ is the strategic advantage from co-opting legitimate symbols (ISSN, Scopus, journal title); $ICS_{noreview}$ represents the cost savings from eliminating actual peer review; $MP_{detection}$ is the penalty paid when the target detects fraud (low because detection requires active verification effort); and $SIP_{noreputationstake}$ is the social immunity premium from having no stake in the legitimate community that would be damaged by exposure.

Empirically, all four components favor the predatory operator. The strategic advantage from co-opting a Scopus-indexed journal's identity is substantial — Scopus indexing is the primary quality signal used by researchers in developing countries where institutional guidance is limited. The cost savings from eliminating peer review are enormous (Shen and Björk found average APCs of $178 for predatory journals in 2014, compared to thousands of dollars in genuine processing costs). Detection rates are low: the Grudniewicz et al. consensus found that even experienced researchers often cannot distinguish predatory from legitimate journals without active verification tools. And the social immunity premium is structurally near-total: operators can rebrand as soon as they are identified, without suffering lasting reputational damage in any community they care about.[3][4][5][7][8][35][36][34]

3.4 Heteronomous Bayesian Updating and Target Vulnerability

The HBU model describes how agents update their beliefs about the legitimacy of communications when their priors were formed in an environment substantially different from the current one, and when they assign authority weights to signal sources that reflect historical rather than current reliability. Formally:

$$P_A(H|E) = \frac{P(E|H)^{w(A)} \times P(H)}{P(E)}$$

where $w(A) > 1$ represents the authority weight the agent assigns to the apparent source. Researchers trained in an era when Scopus indexing was a reliable quality signal will assign an elevated $w(A)$ to Scopus claims, updating their posterior toward P(legitimate) in proportion to that authority weight — even when the base rate of fraudulent invitations in the population of solicitation emails they receive is now very high.

This explains a pattern documented extensively in the literature: researchers who publish in predatory journals are not systematically less intelligent or less trained than those who avoid them. Perlin et al. found that faculty who published in predatory journals frequently did so unknowingly, misled by indexing claims and professional language. Studies of developing country researchers found that in environments where "Scopus indexed" is used as a direct credential by institutional promotion committees, the HBU miscalibration is essentially a rational response to institutional incentive structures. The same prior — "Scopus-indexed journals are legitimate" — that was rational when formed is now being exploited by operators who have learned to co-opt Scopus indexing without satisfying its quality conditions.[2][8][35][36]

3.5 The GIMT and Dynamic Classification Failure

The Generalized Intentionality Mismatch Theorem identifies Dynamic Classification Failure (Failure Mode 6) as the most strategically exploited of the classification errors: the target correctly applies its classification heuristic to available evidence, but the available evidence has been specifically manufactured to produce a misclassification. The hijacked journal specimen is a case study in engineered Dynamic Classification Failure: the Scopus

ISSN, the journal name, the indexing claims — every element has been selected to trigger the "legitimate journal" classification correctly and in doing so to produce an incorrect outcome.

This is analytically distinct from ordinary deception by omission or ambiguity. The predatory operator does not merely fail to provide disconfirming information — it actively constructs a set of confirming signals specifically calibrated to the target's classification system. This is why the parallel with Dawkins's Leucochloridium paradoxum is exact: the parasite does not merely exploit the snail's existing behavior — it manufactures a specific stimulus that drives a behavior the snail would not otherwise produce.

4. Cross-Domain Structural Analysis: Six Modalities

4.1 The Six Predatory Modalities

The predatory publishing ecosystem encompasses six distinct operational modalities, each targeting a different segment of the symbolic recognition market. All six share the structural properties identified in Section 3, but they differ in target population, extraction mechanism, and symbolic vocabulary.

Academic predatory journals are the most extensively documented modality. Since Beall coined the term in 2010 and published the first systematic list in 2011, the literature has grown substantially. Shen and Björk's 2015 longitudinal study, the most cited quantitative study in the field, documented growth from 53,000 articles in 2010 to approximately 420,000 in 2014, published by roughly 8,000 active journals. The Grudniewicz et al. consensus definition, reached through a 12-hour Delphi process in 2019 involving 43 researchers from 10 countries, established the operative definition: "Predatory journals and publishers are entities that prioritize self-interest at the expense of scholarship and are characterized by false or misleading information, deviation from best editorial and publication practices, a lack of transparency, and/or the use of aggressive and indiscriminate solicitation practices".[1][37][38][39][6][7]

Hijacked and cloned journals represent a more sophisticated second modality. Rather than constructing a plausible-sounding fake institution, these operations appropriate the identity of a legitimate indexed journal, using its exact name, ISSN, and indexing status while operating from an unrelated domain. Abalkina's comprehensive 2024 study identified at least 67 such journals that had penetrated Scopus since 2013. A study of the plagiarism prevalence in hijacked journal output found that 66% of analyzed papers contained plagiarism and 28% showed text similarity above 25% — indicating that the fraudulent journals are not merely collecting fees but functioning as laundering operations for dishonest research. The hijacked journal represents the maximal case of institutional mimicry: rather than building a facsimile of legitimate infrastructure, it steals the infrastructure itself.[18][40][19]

Vanity poetry anthology schemes constitute the oldest documented modality in the creative writing domain. The International Library of Poetry (ILP), founded in Owings Mills, Maryland in 1983, established the template that has defined the sector for over four decades. The Library of Congress has classified Poetry.com and its affiliates as vanity publishers. The operation drew submissions from over five million poets, informed each that their poem had been "selected" for publication in an anthology priced at $59.95 — which the "published" author was expected to purchase, as no complimentary copies were provided. The Winning Writers guide and SFWA's Writer Beware both document the current persistence of analogous schemes under various names. The Library of Congress's online guide to amateur poetry anthologies, established specifically to help people find poems they had published through these operations, testifies to the cultural scale of the phenomenon.[41][42][43][44][28]

Pay-to-play literary contests operate on a similar but distinct mechanism. Writers are induced to enter contests, informed they are semi-finalists or winners, and then offered publication contingent on fee payment or book purchase. SFWA's Victoria Strauss, who has maintained Writer Beware for decades, characterizes the standard mechanism: "The contest isn't a real contest, however. There may be some degree of selectivity, but if so, it's minimal: the aim, after all, is to collect paying customers. Most of those who submit are told that they are semi-finalists and offered publication". The Famous Poets Society, Sparrowgrass Poetry Forum, the Amherst Society, and Poetry Press are among the documented operators in this category.[42][28]

Predatory vanity presses targeting book authors represent a higher-value extraction modality. Literary agent Mary DeMuth documents fifteen operational characteristics: unprompted email contact with extensive flattery, immediate acceptance without quality evaluation, a basic publishing package above $5,000 escalating through upsell cascades into tens of thousands of dollars, artificial internal award programs, and in some cases the sale of author contact lists to fraudulent "literary agents" who pursue the same targets for further extraction. Lit Hub's account of one author's five-year relationship with a predatory vanity press provides a detailed first-person case study of the full extraction cascade, from initial contact through increasingly expensive marketing packages and the gradual realization that the investment would never be recouped.[29][45]

Elite recognition schemes constitute the sixth modality — operations that sell inclusion in directories, awards, or professional registries. Writer Beware's 2025 report documents the growth of "profiteering contests and awards (which exist to enrich their owners, rather than to honor writers)". These operations target the specific vulnerability of the established professional who has not yet achieved institutional recognition and is susceptible to the offer of a credential that can be listed in a curriculum vitae.[33]

4.2 Six Structural Invariants

Across all six modalities, six structural invariants are present. Their universality is itself theoretically significant: it is evidence that these are not independent phenomena but instances of a common generative mechanism.

Invariant 1: Symbolic recognition precedes financial extraction. In every modality, the first communication establishes the target as having been selected, recognized, or identified as worthy. The financial demand follows as the natural next step to actualize a recognition that has already been conferred. This sequencing is not incidental — it is the core operational logic. The initial recognition event must be experienced before the extraction request is made, because it is the recognition event that creates the motivation to pay. A solicitation that opened with a fee request would be immediately identified as commercial; a solicitation that opens with a recognition event engages the target's investment in their own identity.

Invariant 2: Institutional mimicry. All six modalities appropriate the symbols of legitimate gatekeeping: ISSN numbers, Scopus indexing, "National" or "International" names, peer-review claims, editorial board listings, certificates of recognition. The predatory entity does not generate new legitimacy — it parasitizes existing legitimacy infrastructure. The cost of building such mimicry has declined dramatically with the availability of domain registration, web publishing, and AI-assisted content generation.

Invariant 3: Universal acceptance masked as selection. In academic predatory journals, acceptance rates approach 100%. In poetry anthology schemes, Writer Beware's Strauss observes that "everyone who submits is told they are a semi-finalist". In vanity presses, DeMuth notes "immediate acceptance of your proposal, mini proposal, or manuscript" as a primary red flag. The simulation of competitive selection is the primary phenotypic structure maintaining the illusion of value. The target's experience of being selected in a competitive process is what generates the psychological investment that will sustain the extraction cascade.[4][28][29][46]

Invariant 4: Staged extraction cascade with sunk-cost amplification. Initial contact is free or nominally priced. Each subsequent stage leverages the psychological commitment created by the prior stage — the Arkes and Blumer sunk-cost effect — to justify the next payment. The predatory vanity press follows a documented progression: initial manuscript evaluation (free) → basic publishing package ($5,000+) → marketing package ($2,000+) → social media services → author coaching → PR packages → bookmarks → Amazon listing optimization. The ILP's equivalent cascade proceeds from free entry → anthology purchase → certificate and plaque → "Editor's Choice" upgrade → invitations to award ceremonies at $600 or more.[43][29][47]

Invariant 5: Rebrand-on-exposure. When an operator's reputation is damaged by exposure, the operation continues under a new name. ILP became Eber & Wein became Poetry Nation; predatory journals acquire new titles and ISSNs after delisting; hijacked journals migrate to new domains when the original clone is flagged in indexing databases. The evolutionary fitness of the operation does not depend on reputation maintenance because the target population — first-time writers, researchers at institutions with limited publishing guidance, scholars under institutional pressure — is continuously renewed.[3][44][34]

Invariant 6: System-level template continuity across operators. The invitation templates recycle verbatim across operators and decades. A researcher identifying predatory academic invitations in 2010 would recognize the structural logic of the 2026 specimen analyzed in this paper. SFWA's Writer Beware documents that the basic pay-to-play anthology template has remained stable since at least the 1980s. This template continuity is not the result of direct coordination — it reflects convergent evolution toward the phenotypic form that most effectively exploits the target's recognition filters. The form is stable because the target's cognitive architecture is stable.[28][47]

5. The Predatory Invitation Phenotype: Evolutionary Formalization

5.1 The PIP Fitness Function

The fitness of a Predatory Invitation Phenotype (PIP) variant can be expressed as:

$$F_{PIP} = P(\text{open}) \times P(\text{engage} \mid \text{open}) \times P(\text{pay} \mid \text{engage}) \times V_{extraction}$$

where:

- $P(\text{open})$ is determined by the subject line and apparent sender identity's mimicry quality — a legitimate journal name and ISSN significantly increases open rates relative to generic spam
- $P(\text{engage} \mid \text{open})$ is determined by the invitation body's superestimulus density: the stacking of flattery, institutional claims, urgency signals, and recognition vocabulary
- $P(\text{pay} \mid \text{engage})$ is determined by the extraction cascade design, the absence of cheap verification signals, and the target's HBU calibration
- $V_{extraction}$ is the expected financial value per paying target, ranging from the $178 average APC documented by Shen and Björk through the $600 conference invitations of ILP to the $10,000+ vanity press packages documented by DeMuth[7][43][29]

Natural selection operates on each parameter independently. Different operator strategies represent different bets about which parameters to optimize. The generic spam predatory journal maximizes operator volume at the expense of per-target yield, operating on high $P(\text{open})$ through simple template reproduction and low $V_{extraction}$. The hijacked journal strategy invests more in mimicry quality — particularly ISSN co-option and Scopus claims — to increase $P(\text{engage} \mid \text{open})$ at moderate per-target cost. The high-end vanity press maximizes $V_{extraction}$ through a personalized extraction cascade that sacrifices breadth for depth.

5.2 The Superestimulus Mechanism

The concept of the superestimulus — introduced by ethologist Niko Tinbergen to describe artificial stimuli that trigger instinctive responses more powerfully than natural stimuli — is directly applicable to the PIP. Legitimate journal invitations are typically brief, specific, editorially characterful, and contain no excess flattery. They have not been selected for their ability to trigger the target's "legitimate opportunity" recognition module — they have been selected for accurate communication. The predatory invitation, by contrast, has been selected specifically for its ability to trigger that module, and has therefore evolved to stack signals more densely and expressively than any authentic invitation would.[39]

The consequence is a systematic asymmetry: the predatory invitation is more recognizable-as-legitimate than legitimate invitations, because it has undergone far more intense selection pressure in the specific dimension of passing cognitive filters. The authentic invitation was never selected for that — it was selected for accurate information transmission. This asymmetry cannot be corrected by calibrating on experience, because more authentic invitations in one's past experience does not recalibrate the target's recognition module to be less responsive to dense legitimacy stacking.

In the academic domain, the relevant superestimuli are: Scopus indexing claims, ISSN numbers, "peer review" rhetoric, "open access" vocabulary, UGC and DGRSDT listings. In the literary domain, the equivalent superestimuli have been documented in Poets & Writers' analysis of ILP communications: "you've penned a wonderful verse... your poem has moved our editorial team", and in the famous account of one ILP letter that allegedly concluded with "may God bless your home and family" — a level of personal affect that no legitimate literary institution would produce in a form letter to a stranger. Both cases involve stimuli that exceed the authentic signal in affective intensity — a reliable marker of manufactured superestimuli.[43]

5.3 The Shen–Björk Inflection and the AI Acceleration

Shen and Björk's 2015 study documented an eight-fold growth in predatory journal article volumes between 2010 and 2014, establishing the baseline trajectory. The University of Colorado Boulder AI detection study of 2025 flagged over 1,000 questionable journals out of 15,200 analyzed, identifying anomalies in article volume, author affiliation distributions, and self-citation patterns. The arXiv preprint "Fake scientific journals are here to stay" (October 2025) confirms that the ecosystem has not contracted despite intensified detection efforts.[6][7][48][49]

The 2024–2026 period represents a qualitative shift in the PIP's evolutionary trajectory. AI-generated spam reached 51% of all spam in April 2025 according to research conducted by Barracuda, Columbia University, and the University of Chicago. A 2024 study found that AI-generated phishing emails achieved a 54% click-through rate compared to 12% for traditional phishing — a 4.5x effectiveness multiplier. The Thesify guide (March 2026) documents the specific application of this technology to academic solicitations: "Advances in generative AI allow scammers to craft personalized invitations that reference your previous papers, conference presentations, or online profiles, and they mimic the style of reputable journals". The February 2026 Facebook Reviewer2 group post documents that predatory AI-generated invitations are now "getting quite sophisticated" in their personalization.[26][21][27][25]

This constitutes a selective sweep in the PIP fitness landscape: AI-enabled personalization dramatically increases $P(\text{open})$ and $P(\text{engage} \mid \text{open})$ at near-zero marginal cost per target. The specimen analyzed in this paper — which correctly identifies the recipient's first name, institutional email, and a journal title relevant to his stated research area — reflects this current adaptive front.

6. The PSO Equilibrium Analysis

6.1 Equilibrium Conditions

The predatory publishing PSO maintains evolutionary stability under five equilibrium conditions, each of which can be assessed independently.

Condition E1 — High information asymmetry. The target cannot reliably distinguish legitimate from predatory at the point of initial contact without investing verification effort that exceeds the expected cost of the fraud itself. Each additional cloned journal increases the verification burden for all researchers. The WCRIF study confirms that 67 hijacked journals have contaminated Scopus — meaning that even the most reliable legitimacy signal available to researchers has been compromised. When the primary verification infrastructure is itself unreliable, verification cannot function as a deterrent.[50][18]

Condition E2 — Structural enforcement gap. The absence of binding enforcement is documented across both domains. Scopus can delist journals but cannot prevent reentry under new identities. WoS has analogous limitations. SFWA's Writer Beware operates as a consumer advocacy service, not a regulatory authority. No cross-jurisdictional legal mechanism addresses predatory publishing at scale. The SFWA 2025 report notes that "the scam industry has shifted heavily overseas" — a pattern consistent with regulatory arbitrage as an evolutionary adaptation to domestic enforcement pressure.[33][34][20]

Condition E3 — Motivated reasoning by targets. HBU predicts that targets weight evidence toward desired conclusions when the authority weight of the apparent source is high. A comprehensive systematic review published in JASIST in 2024 found that publication pressure, particularly in developing country contexts, creates a structural predisposition toward accepting legitimacy signals from journals offering rapid acceptance. The Global South analysis documents the compounded vulnerability: institutional promotion criteria that directly reward Scopus publications create an environment where the miscalibration of HBU priors is instrumentally rational given the incentive structure.[8][35][9][36]

Condition E4 — Operator impunity. The Maynard Smith ESS analysis applies directly. If the predatory strategy confers higher expected fitness than the honest strategy — because the SIP component of the Dennett-Nash Gap ensures near-zero reputational costs from exposure in any community the operator participates in — then the predatory strategy is individually rational regardless of its systemic costs. The system is in an equilibrium analogous to the Hawk-Dove game: the predatory strategy is locally dominant for operators who have no stake in the communities they exploit.[51][14][15]

Condition E5 — Evolutionary feedback loop. Detection tools create selection pressure toward more sophisticated mimicry, which generates new detection tools, which creates further selection pressure. This is an arms race in the strict biological sense. Beall's List drove early operators to refine their presentation; the Grudniewicz consensus definition drove operators to simulate more credible peer review claims; AI-assisted detection tools are now driving operators toward AI-assisted personalization. The ESS is not a static equilibrium but a co-evolutionary trajectory in which the PIP phenotype and its detection environment evolve in tandem.

6.2 Why Financial Detection Does Not Disrupt the Equilibrium

A common intuition about predatory publishing is that exposing and publicizing the fee structures of fraudulent operators should be sufficient to disrupt the system. This intuition misunderstands the structure of the PSO. The financial extraction is downstream of the symbolic transaction — the recognition event that has already been conferred before any fee is mentioned. By the time the target encounters the fee request, the psychological investment in the recognized-author identity is already established. The Arkes-Blumer sunk-cost mechanism and HBU's posterior updating ensure that the prior experience of being recognized will be weighted heavily in the decision to pay.

The SFWA documentation confirms this: Writer Beware notes that pay-to-play anthology solicitations "often don't mention that a cash outlay is involved — you usually have to dig pretty deep into the submission guidelines to find that out". DeMuth's analysis of predatory vanity press operations documents the same structure: initial contact involves no fee request, establishes extensive positive relationship through free services and enthusiastic responses, and only introduces the financial extraction mechanism after substantial emotional investment has been generated.[28][29]

7. The Arms Race with Detection: 2010–2026

7.1 The Detection Ecology

The detection ecology for predatory publishing has developed rapidly since Beall's List was first published in 2011. The current ecosystem includes Beall's List (maintained by anonymous contributors after Beall took it down under pressure in 2017), the Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker (now at 400+ entries), the Think Check Submit initiative, COPE membership verification, SFWA's Writer Beware for the literary domain, and the Winning Writers guide for poetry contests. The University of Colorado Boulder AI-based detection system (2025) represents the next generation of detection tools, using anomaly detection in publication metadata to flag questionable journals at scale.[1][3][42][28][33][48]

Each generation of detection tools has been met with a corresponding evolutionary adaptation in the PIP phenotype. The detection ecology and the PIP are co-evolving, and the predatory operators occupy the adaptation-leading position in this arms race because: they have more specific fitness objectives (optimize for P(pay)), they operate with lower institutional constraints, they can redeploy capital immediately after exposure, and they have gained access to the same AI tools that detection researchers are using.

7.2 The AI-Assisted Wave of 2024–2026

The application of generative AI to predatory invitation production represents the most significant evolutionary step in the PIP phenotype since the transition from print to email solicitation in the 1990s. Several dimensions of this adaptation have been documented in 2025–2026 literature.

AI-generated emails have achieved statistical indistinguishability from human-written communications in studies of urgency signaling and click-through rates. The specific application to academic fraud includes: scraping publication records from Scopus, SSRN, Zenodo, and Google Scholar to identify potential targets; extracting paper titles and research keywords to generate contextually relevant invitations; generating personalized body text that references specific prior work; and deploying at scale through automated systems.[26][21][27]

The Times Higher Education documented AI-based fake paper submissions in August 2025: "As an editor, I am receiving submissions from spurious authors consisting of previously published papers altered by AI" with iThenticate similarity scores of only 2–5% — specifically engineered to evade plagiarism detection. This represents the extension of the AI adaptation beyond the invitation phase into the submission and publication phases themselves.[52]

AI scams more broadly surged 1,210% in 2025, far outpacing 195% growth in traditional fraud. The academic publishing domain has not been immune to this trajectory. The evolutionary implication is direct: the PIP phenotype is undergoing a rapid adaptive radiation driven by the availability of AI-assisted personalization, with the 2026 detection ecosystem facing an order-of-magnitude increase in the sophistication and volume of fraudulent invitations.[27]

8. Symbolic Capital and the Bourdieu-EPT Synthesis

8.1 The Field Theory Account

Bourdieu's theory of symbolic capital provides a complementary analytical lens for the PSO account developed in this paper. In Bourdieu's field theory, each social field — the academic field, the literary field, the legal field — is structured by the distribution of field-specific capital: academic capital (degrees, publications, citations, chairs), literary capital (prizes, critical recognition, canonical standing), and the symbolic capital that converts these field-specific currencies into general prestige.[11][53]

Access to the legitimate mechanisms of capital accumulation is structurally restricted. In the academic field, the gatekeepers of symbolic capital are peer-reviewed journals, prestigious publishers, grant agencies, and tenure committees. In the literary field, they are prize committees, literary agents, established publishers, and the critical apparatus. Both sets of gatekeepers are scarce relative to the population of aspirants. The gap between the universal distribution of the desire for recognition and the scarce access to legitimate recognition mechanisms constitutes the ecological niche that predatory publishing exploits.

8.2 Unauthorized Capital Minting

Predatory publishers can be understood as operating an unauthorized mint for symbolic capital. The legitimate mint — the peer-review process, the editorial selection procedure, the prize committee deliberation — produces symbolic capital through processes that are costly, selective, and institutionally embedded. The predatory mint produces the appearance of symbolic capital through processes that are cheap, universal, and institutionally unembedded. The product is visually indistinguishable from legitimate symbolic capital for long enough to support the extraction transaction.

The critical insight from the EPT-Bourdieu synthesis is that the illegitimate product does not need to hold its value indefinitely — it only needs to hold its value long enough for the target to internalize the recognized-author identity and pay for its materialization. Once the payment is made, the predatory operator's interest in the target ends. The target subsequently discovers that the "publication" carries no weight in legitimate field evaluations, that the "prize" is unrecognized, that the "journal" is not indexed — but by then the extraction has been completed and the sunk-cost mechanism makes it psychologically difficult for the target to abandon the investment publicly.

The Bourdieu-EPT synthesis explains why these operations have proven remarkably durable across four decades of documented activity in the literary domain and over fifteen years in the academic domain. The desire for recognition that they exploit is not a contingent cultural artifact but a structural feature of any field organized around the competitive distribution of scarce symbolic capital. As long as legitimate capital remains scarce, unauthorized minting will find a market.

9. Implications for the Research Program and Future Directions

9.1 The Live Specimen as Methodological Contribution

The March 30, 2026 specimen provides a primary empirical anchor for manuscript #9516 that distinguishes it methodologically from prior work in this space. Most studies of predatory publishing have relied on third-party documentation, historical archives, or survey data. The present paper offers a first-person, timestamped specimen that was received, analyzed, and published as part of an ongoing research program — a mode of evidence generation that is unusual in this literature and that positions the paper as participant-observation as well as theoretical analysis.

The specimen's significance is enhanced by several features. It arrived during an active research session on the same topic — a coincidence that is theoretically interesting: the scraping of the author's SSRN/Zenodo/Google Scholar profile was accurate enough to produce a contextually relevant journal title. The timing (1:34 AM) is consistent with AI-automated batch sending. The Gmail address indicates either very early-stage operation or deliberate choice to avoid domain verification services. The deferred disclosure of fees is consistent with the staged extraction cascade mechanism. The specimen thus instantiates, in real time, every theoretical construct developed in this paper.

9.2 Connections to the Agentic Fraud Paper

The Agentic Fraud as Extended Phenotype paper (Zenodo: 10.5281/zenodo.18924282) provides the formal scaffolding for the AI-assisted evolution documented in Section 7. The ScamAgent framework models the deployment of LLMs as instruments of L1 operators seeking to produce L3-mimicking communications at scale. The 2024–2026 AI wave documented here is a direct instantiation of the ScamAgent model: predatory journal operators are deploying LLMs to generate personalized invitations that achieve the contextual specificity previously only available through human research, at a cost that approaches zero per invitation. The Dennett-Nash Gap's SA component is being systematically enlarged by AI-assisted personalization.

9.3 Connections to the Sycophancy Paper

The Sycophancy as Extended Phenotype paper (Zenodo: 10.5281/zenodo.18943464) provides the micropsychological mechanism operative in both the "may God bless your home and family" ILP letter and the "rigorous evaluation process" academic invitation. Both are instances of manufactured affirmation — communications engineered to trigger the target's affirmation-reception module more powerfully than authentic communications would. The sycophancy literature documents the evolutionary stability of flattery as a strategy in human communication systems; the present paper documents the same stability in the specific domain of publishing solicitation.

9.4 The Formal Model as a New Contribution

The PIP fitness function developed in Section 5.1 represents a formal contribution that, to the best of documented knowledge, has not appeared in the predatory publishing literature. The existing literature is empirically rich but formally thin — it catalogs, defines, and describes predatory publishing but does not provide a mechanism-level formal model of why specific PIP variants outcompete others, why AI personalization constitutes a fitness-increasing mutation, or what the ESS trajectory of the arms race predicts. The fitness function provides a framework within which these questions can be addressed quantitatively.

10. Conclusion

This paper has argued that predatory publishing — across the full spectrum of academic journals, hijacked clones, vanity poetry anthologies, literary prize schemes, and vanity presses — constitutes a textbook case of Parasitic Spontaneous Order. The system extracts value from the symbolic recognition infrastructure of legitimate publishing without contributing to that infrastructure's maintenance. It is evolutionarily stable under current institutional conditions. It has evolved adaptively in response to detection pressure, with the AI-assisted personalization wave of 2024–2026 representing its current most sophisticated adaptive frontier.

The theoretical contribution of this paper rests on three claims. First, that the fundamental currency of predatory publishing is symbolic recognition rather than money: the financial extraction is downstream of a prior symbolic transaction in which the target has already been persuaded to identify as a recognized author, researcher, or poet. This makes it analytically misleading to treat predatory publishing as simple fraud — it is a system that exploits the universal human desire for recognition in the specific institutional environments where recognition is legitimately scarce and symbolically powerful.

Second, that the structural isomorphism between academic and literary predatory publishing — despite entirely different target motivations (institutional publish-or-perish pressure versus intrinsic desire for recognition) — is strong evidence for a common generative mechanism. The six structural invariants documented in Section 4.2 cannot have arisen independently across decades of separate development without a shared underlying logic. That logic is provided by the EPT account: the PIP is a cultural replicator that has evolved the same phenotypic form in every environment where symbolic recognition constitutes a scarce resource.

Third, that the system is best understood not as a collection of isolated frauds but as a Parasitic Spontaneous Order — a self-organizing, evolutionarily stable ecosystem that will persist and evolve as long as the underlying conditions (symbolic recognition scarcity, enforcement gap, high information asymmetry, motivated reasoning by targets) remain structurally in place. Detection tools that do not address these underlying conditions will paradoxically accelerate the evolution of more sophisticated PIP variants by creating selection pressure on the phenotype. The ESS analysis predicts that the predatory invitation will become increasingly indistinguishable from legitimate invitations over the current decade — a trajectory that the AI-assisted personalization wave has already set in motion.

The author used AI language models (Claude, Perplexity) to assist with locating sources, extracting bibliographic information from the predatory publishing literature, and reviewing draft text for consistency. The theoretical framework (PSO, PIP fitness function, EPT application), empirical specimen analysis, and all interpretive claims are the author's original contribution. The author takes full responsibility for all claims made in this paper.

Abalkina, A. (2024). Challenges posed by hijacked journals in Scopus. Journal of the American Society for Information Science and Technology, 75(3). https://doi.org/10.1002/asi.24855[18][19]

Abalkina, A. (2025, December). The Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker now has 400 entries. Retraction Watch. https://retractionwatch.com/2025/12/26/retraction-watch-hijacked-journal-checker-now-has-400-entries/[3]

Abalkina, A. (2024). Challenges posed by hijacked journals in Scopus (conference paper). 8th World Conference on Research Integrity. https://www.wcrif.org/downloads/former-conferences/8th-wcri-call-for-bids/papers-and-presentations-5/699-wcri2024-anna-abalkina-[50]

Abalkina, A., & Sabel, C. (2024). Prevalence of plagiarism in hijacked journals: a text similarity analysis. Science and Engineering Ethics, 30. https://doi.org/10.1080/08989621.2024.2387210[40]

Beall, J. (2013). Predatory publishing is just one of the consequences of gold open access. Learned Publishing, 26(2), 79–83.[1]

Bourdieu, P. (1986). The forms of capital. In J. Richardson (Ed.), Handbook of Theory and Research for the Sociology of Education (pp. 241–258). Greenwood.[11]

Clark, J., & Smith, R. (2015). Firm action needed on predatory journals. BMJ, 350, h210.[8]

Dawkins, R. (1982). The Extended Phenotype: The Gene as the Unit of Selection. W.H. Freeman.[12][31]

DeMuth, M. (2022, November). 15 traits of predatory vanity publishers. Mary DeMuth Literary. https://marydemuthliterary.com/vanitypublisher/[29]

Dodd, A. T. (2022, August). What five years with a predatory vanity press taught me about art and success. Lit Hub. https://lithub.com/what-five-years-with-a-predatory-vanity-press-taught-me-about-art-and-success/[45]

EditorsCafe (2025, July). The rising threat of journal hijacking and cloned websites in scholarly publishing. https://editorscafe.org/details.php?id=80[20]

Forbes (2025, June). AI is behind 50% of spam — and now it's hacking your accounts. Forbes. https://www.forbes.com/sites/daveywinder/2025/06/20/ai-is-behind-50-of-spam[26]

Grudniewicz, A., Moher, D., Cobey, K. D., et al. (2019). Predatory journals: no definition, no defence. Nature, 576(7786), 210–212. https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-019-03759-y[54][38]

Grudniewicz, A., Moher, D., Cobey, K. D., et al. (2020). Defining predatory journals and responding to the threat they pose: a modified Delphi consensus process. BMJ Open, 10(2), e035561. https://doi.org/10.1136/bmjopen-2019-035561[4][5]

Hayek, F. A. (1973). Law, Legislation and Liberty, Vol. 1: Rules and Order. University of Chicago Press.[13]

Jalalian, M. (2015). The story of fake impact factor companies and how we detected them. Electronic Physician, 7(2), 1069–1072.[46]

Julkaisufoorumi (2024, March). Hijacked journals as a nuisance to the scientific community. https://julkaisufoorumi.fi/en/news/hijacked-journals-nuisance-scientific-community[16]

Library of Congress (2012, March). Poetry contests, the National Library of Poetry, and amateur poetry anthologies. Library of Congress Blog. https://blogs.loc.gov/catbird/2012/03/poetry-contests-the-national-library-of-poetry-and-amateur-poetry-anthologies/[41]

Maynard Smith, J., & Price, G. R. (1973). The logic of animal conflict. Nature, 246(5427), 15–18.[14]

Maynard Smith, J. (1982). Evolution and the Theory of Games. Cambridge University Press.[55][15]

Perlin, M. S., Imasato, T., & Borenstein, D. (2018). Is predatory publishing a real threat? Evidence from a large database study. Scientometrics, 116(1), 255–273.[2]

PMC / Bongiovanni, I., et al. (2024, July). Investigating country-specific perceptions of predatory journals. Research Integrity and Peer Review, 9. https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11326802/[35]

Poets & Writers (2017, February). The Contester: Poetry.com struggles for legitimacy. https://www.pw.org/content/contester_poetrycom_struggles_legitimacy[43]

Retraction Watch (2021, May). How hijacked journals keep fooling one of the world's leading databases. https://retractionwatch.com/2021/05/26/how-hijacked-journals-keep-fooling-one-of-the-worlds-leading-databases/[34]

Retraction Watch (2023, April). A high-quality cloned journal has duped hundreds of scholars. https://retractionwatch.com/2023/04/04/a-high-quality-cloned-journal-has-duped-hundreds-of-scholars-and-has-no-reason-to-stop/[56]

SFWA / Writer Beware (2025, August). Pay-to-play anthologies. https://www.sfwa.org/other-resources/for-authors__trashed/writer-beware/anthologies/[28]

SFWA / Writer Beware (2025, August). SFWA presents: Get to know Writer Beware. https://www.sfwa.org/2025/08/12/sfwa-presents-get-to-know-writer-beware-part-1-history-and-mission/[33]

Shen, C., & Björk, B.-C. (2015). 'Predatory' open access: a longitudinal study of article volumes and market characteristics. BMC Medicine, 13, 230. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12916-015-0469-2[6][7]

Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2024). Evolutionary game theory. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/game-evolutionary/[14]

Thesify AI (2026, March). Predatory journals in 2026: red flags, risks and safe choices. https://www.thesify.ai/blog/predatory-journals-2026-guide[21]

Times Higher Education (2025, August). AI-based fake papers are a new threat to academic publishing. https://www.timeshighereducation.com/opinion/ai-based-fake-papers-are-new-threat-academic-publishing[52]

Vectra AI (2026, March). AI scams in 2026: how they work and how to detect them. https://www.vectra.ai/topics/ai-scams[27]

Walters, W. H. (2022). Predatory journal articles cited long after blacklisting. Accountability in Research, 29(4), 235–252.[2]

Wikipedia (2024). Poetry.com. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Poetry.com[44]

Winning Writers (2026, March). Contests and services to avoid. https://winningwriters.com/the-best-free-literary-contests/contests-to-avoid[42]

Writer Beware Blog (2011, May). Pay to play anthologies. https://writerbeware.blog/2011/05/05/pay-to-play-anthologies/[47]

References

[1] Beall's List – of Potential Predatory Journals and Publishers - A list of potential predatory publishers created by a librarian Jeffrey Beall. We will only update l...

[2] Understanding 'Predatory' Journals and Implications for Guiding ... - This article draws on a broad body of research to explore the factors that enable predatory journals...

[3] The Retraction Watch Hijacked Journal Checker now has 400 entries - Evidence shows the strategy of some hijacked journals is cherry-picking. They create a clone website...

[4] Defining predatory journals and responding to the threat they pose - These consensus items included the characteristics, markers and empirically derived data to be inclu...

[5] Defining predatory journals and responding to the threat they pose - We reached consensus on 18 items out of a total of 33 to be included in a consensus definition of pr...

[6] 'Predatory' open access: a longitudinal study of article volumes and ... - Over the studied period, predatory journals have rapidly increased their publication volumes from 53...

[7] 'Predatory' open access: a longitudinal study of article volumes and ... - Results: Over the studied period, predatory journals have rapidly increased their publication volume...

[8] [[PDF] Predatory journals and developing country research](https://www.wcrif.org/downloads/former-conferences/5th-wcri-in-amsterdam-2017/papers-and-presentations-3/275-wcri2017-jocalyn-clark-predatory-journals-and-research-in-developing-countries) - Predatory journals a global problem that disproportionately affects developing country researchers a...

[9] [[PDF] Predatory publishing from the Global South perspective](https://open.uct.ac.za/server/api/core/bitstreams/030f56a3-220f-4804-b57c-7acd1a492759/content) - What we find intriguing is the fact that Beall has published his definition of predatory publishing ...

[10] Predatory journals: Who publishes in them and why? - ScienceDirect - Predatory fake journals (PFJs) are located in 52 different countries. The highest number of research...

[11] Bourdieu's “Symbolic Capital”: The Hidden Power of Prestige - Bourdieu's “Symbolic Capital”: The Hidden Power of Prestige What makes a university degree, a blue c...

[12] [[PDF] The extended phenotype: The gene as the unit of selection: By ...](https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/The-extended-phenotype:-The-gene-as-the-unit-of-By-Flinn/398077e1068491296fd831cfc055f9afa20f47b8) - The extended phenotype: The gene as the unit of selection: By Richard Dawkins, Oxford and San Franci...

[13] What Is Spontaneous Order? - OUCI - ... Hayek, “spontaneous order” has become an influential concept in social theory. It seeks to expla...

[14] Evolutionary Game Theory - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy - In 1972, Maynard Smith first introduced the concept of an evolutionarily stable strategy (hereafter ...

[15] Evolutionarily stable strategy - Wikipedia - An evolutionarily stable strategy (ESS) is a strategy (or set of strategies) that is impermeable whe...

[16] Hijacked journals as a nuisance to the scientific community - Predatory publishers hijack journals to mislead researchers into submitting their manuscripts to a c...

[17] Studies in Science of Science - Scimago Journal & Country Rank - Scope. Studies in Science of Science is a comprehensive academic journal founded in 1983 by the Chin...

[18] Challenges posed by hijacked journals in Scopus - Through an analysis of known lists of hijacked journals, the study identified at least 67 hijacked j...

[19] Challenges posed by hijacked journals in Scopus - Abalkina - 2024 - Of these, 33 journals indexed unauthorized content in Scopus and 23 compromised the homepage link in...

[20] The Rising Threat of Journal Hijacking and Cloned Websites in Scholarly Publishing: A Call to Action - Leave a Comment

Your email address will not be published. Required fields are marked *

In rece...

[21] Predatory Journals in 2026: Red Flags, Risks and Safe Choices - AI-Generated Phishing Emails and Personalized Predatory Journal Spam. Advances in generative AI allo...

[22] How to identify Fake, cloned, predatory journals and conferences - How to identify Fake, cloned, predatory journals and conferences. 1.2K views · 1 year ago ...more. E...

[23] How to identify Fake, cloned, predatory journals and conferences - How to identify Fake, cloned, predatory journals and conferences. 212 views · 2 years ago ...more. E...

[24] Predatory Invitations from Journals: More Than Just a Nuisance? - Physicians and academic researchers are frequently targeted with spam invitations to submit manuscri...

[25] The predatory AI-generated scam emails are getting ... - Facebook - The predatory AI-generated scam emails are getting quite sophisticated. Every author receiving an in...

[26] AI Is Behind 50% Of Spam — And Now It's Hacking Your Accounts - It's official: more than half of the spam that you receive has been created using AI tools. That's t...

[27] AI scams in 2026: how they work and how to detect them - Vectra AI - AI scams surged 1,210% in 2025, far outpacing the 195% growth in traditional fraud, and projected lo...

[28] PAY-TO-PLAY ANTHOLOGIES - SFWA - It invites submissions, but does not produce anthologies. Writer Beware hears from many poets wantin...

[29] 15 Traits of Predatory Vanity Publishers - Mary DeMuth Literary - What had happened: the predatory publishing house must've sold their author list to unscrupulous “ag...

[30] Richard Dawkins, "The Extended Phenotype" (Book Note) - YouTube - Richard Dawkins, "The Extended Phenotype" (Book Note) #richarddawkins #gene #biology #evolution #hum...

[31] The Long Reach of the Gene (by Richard Dawkins) - YouTube - ... extended phenotype. 00:00 The Long Reach of the Gene 01:00 Darwinian selection works on phenotyp...

[32] Hayek and Spontaneous Orders | Semantic Scholar - Friedrich A. Hayek's work spans over more than forty years and encompasses a number of social discip...

[33] SFWA Presents: Get to Know Writer Beware® (Part 1: History and ... - More recently, the scam industry has shifted heavily overseas. Is there a reason why international s...

[34] How hijacked journals keep fooling one of the world's leading ... - It keeps happening.

There was the case of Talent Development and Excellence, which cloned an exis...

[35] Investigating Country-Specific Perceptions of Predatory Journals ... - This systematic review aims to identify the countries most active in combatting predatory journals a...

[36] Pressure to publish is more damaging in the Global South - SOUTH AFRICA Predatory publishing is a threat to scientists' integrity. GLOBAL University rankings s...

[37] Global Research Trends in Predatory Publishing: A Bibliometric and ... - We analysed global publication and citation trends in predatory publishing research, as well as geog...

[38] [[PDF] Predatory journals: no definition, no defence](https://ccr.life.edu/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/Grudniewicz-2019-Predatory-journal-no-diffeence-no-defense.pdf) - The consensus definition reached was: "Predatory journals and publishers are entities that prioritiz...

[39] Comment | Predatory journals: No definition, no defence. - Predatory journals and publishers are entities that prioritize self-interest at the expense of schol...

[40] Prevalence of plagiarism in hijacked journals: A text similarity analysis - A study found that 67 hijacked journals have infiltrated Scopus since 2013. Of these, 33 journals in...

[41] Poetry Contests, the National Library of Poetry, and Amateur Poetry ... - To help people find poems they've had published by amateur poetry publishers, the Library has create...

[42] Contests and Services to Avoid - Contests and Services to Avoid. More Scam-Fighting Resources Warning signs of a bad literary contest...

[43] The Contester: Poetry.com Struggles for Legitimacy - Poets & Writers - No entry fee? Little chance of rejection? Any poet worth her iamb has reason to be suspicious. And, ...

[44] Poetry.com - Wikipedia

[45] What Five Years with a Predatory Vanity Press Taught Me About Art ... - What Five Years with a Predatory Vanity Press Taught Me About Art and Success. Alexa T. Dodd on a Bo...

[46] Predatory Journals - We are creating a free and open list of predatory publishers and journals to help researchers and or...

[47] Pay to Play Anthologies - Writer Beware - The official blog of Writer Beware® shines a bright light into the dark corners of the shadow-world ...

[48] AI exposes 1,000+ fake science journals - ScienceDaily - By analyzing journal websites for red flags like fake ... predatory journals that exploit researcher...

[49] [[PDF] Fake scientific journals are here to stay - arXiv](https://arxiv.org/pdf/2510.23146.pdf) - In a few cases, fraudulent journals even managed the unthinkable: articles published on their fake w...

[50] [[PDF] Challenges posed by hijacked journals in Scopus](https://www.wcrif.org/downloads/former-conferences/8th-wcri-call-for-bids/papers-and-presentations-5/699-wcri2024-anna-abalkina-challenges-posed-by-hijacked-journals-in-scopus) - Scopus has been mentioned in numerous cases of papers indexed from hijacked journals. • The goal of ...

[51] Evolutionary Stable Strategy: Game Theory | StudySmarter - Evolutionary Stable Strategy (ESS) is a game theory concept representing a strategy that cannot be o...

[52] AI-based fake papers are a new threat to academic publishing - As an editor, I am receiving submissions from spurious authors consisting of previously published pa...

[53] Professionalism as symbolic capital: Materials for a Bourdieusian ... - Pierre Bourdieu has given a brief but fierce critique of the concept of “profession” that calls for ...

[54] Predatory journals: no definition, no defence - Nature - Leading scholars and publishers from ten countries have agreed a definition of predatory publishing ...

[55] Library: John Maynard Smith: The Evolutionary Stable Strategy - PBS - In probing evolution from this point of view, Smith has employed mathematical tools, including what ...

[56] A high-quality cloned journal has duped hundreds of scholars, and ... - Have you heard about hijacked journals, which take over legitimate publications’ *titles, ISSNs, ...